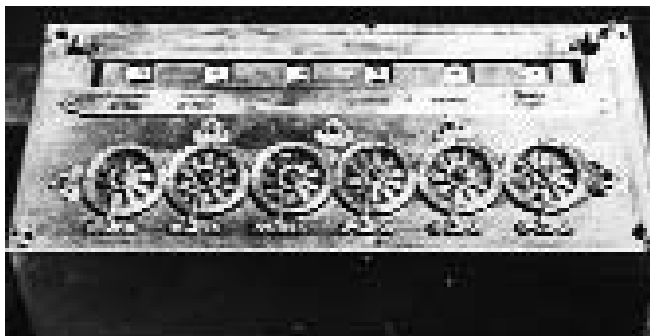




The second-most famous calculator of the 17th century

1671

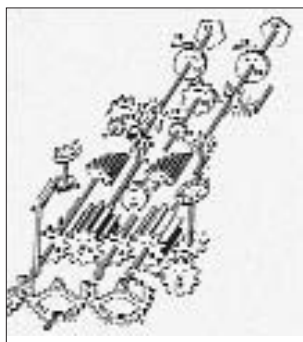
The great German mathematician Gottfried Wilhelm von Leibniz designed a multiplying machine called the Stepped Reckoner. It could multiply numbers of up to five and 12 digits to give a 16-digit result.

We mention this because Leibniz, if you remember, invented the calculus at around the same time as Newton, and there are hard-liners on both sides who argue for their respective champion regarding the invention.

1786

J H Müller, an army officer, actually predated Charles Babbage (we'll come to the man later) in regards the idea of the "Difference Engine."

Müller envisioned (it was never built) a mechanical calculator for determining polynomial values using Newton's method of differences. Now that's advanced maths, and it implies two things: (a) We won't go into it, and (b) It shows that mechanical calculators, by the end of the 18th century, had progressed well beyond addition and multiplication.



Leibniz's Stepped Reckoner: a diagram, not the actual thing